

Supported OS and installation

GNS3 is a cross-platform tool and is available for Windows, Linux and MacOS. Performance will be slightly better in Linux but differences would not be significant if you are running it on modern hardware. GNS3 depends on several other programs to operate. These dependencies, including WinPCAP, Dynamips and Qemu along with GNS3, are all chosen by default at the time of installation.

Note: Installation files can be found in EFY Plus DVD that came with this magazine.

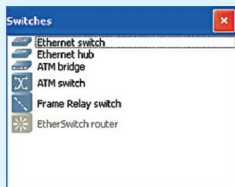


Fig 4: Switches

a suitable choice to experiment with features or to check configurations that need to be deployed later on real devices. For example, you can connect your virtual network to real ones or capture packets using Wireshark to start with your experiments.

Why GNS3

The key feature which sets GNS3 apart from the other router simulators in market is that you can actually work on the same operating systems as in real networks and simulate them with higher accuracy in virtual environment.

There are several other router simulators in the market, but with the downside of being limited to the command line that a developer can choose to include. Also, these are not always accurate as the real network.

Most likely, you will find some commands or parameters which are not supported when working on a

practice lab. Moreover, the other simulators can only provide a representation of the output of a simulated router where the accuracy of such representations depends only on the developer. But with GNS3, which allows you to run an actual Cisco IOS, you can see the exact output the IOS produces and have access to any command or parameter supported by the Cisco IOS.

Additionally, GNS3 is an open source, free program for you to use. However, licensing restrictions require you to provide your own Cisco IOSs to use with GNS3. Also, throughput provided in a virtual environment by GNS3 is around 1000 packets per second while a normal router will provide a hundred to a thousand times greater throughput.

We do not say GNS3 can take the place of a real router, but it is a tool for creating a lab environment which can provide you a good learning and testing closest to the real ones.

Additional support

To download the latest versions and support, visit the official website www.gns3.net. Official documentation and video tutorials are available at the website for your help. For any technical support, you can contact GNS3 community forum and social media sites. Also, a collection of exercises/labs to learn more with GNS3 is available at the website.

An IRC channel is also available on Freenode dedicated servers, which can be accessed via <irc://irc.freenode.net:6667/gns3>. You can talk about anything concerning GNS3—future releases, new features and ideas on this channel.

Start simulating

Now you can experiment with configuring virtual networks on a PC or a Raspberry Pi running Linux, and simulate in the closest possible way to how the real networks perform. ●

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